Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Roger Kellaway

Roger Kellaway has enjoyed a fruitful career in music as a pianist, composer and arranger. He was born in Newton, Massachusetts on November 1, 1939. He studied piano as a child and attended the New England Conservatory. After playing bass with Jimmy McPartland he moved to New York and played piano with numerous jazz artists, including Ben Webster, Clark Terry and Sonny Rollins. He re-settled in Los Angeles and performed with Don Ellis, Tom Scott and Joni Mitchell. Roger was Bobby Darin's musical director in the late 60s and wrote prolifically for television and film. Some of his most distinctive compositions have been for the Roger Kellaway Cello Quartet.

Roger was interviewed in Los Angeles on February 14, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are filming in Los Angeles for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. It's a real pleasure for me to have one of my favorite piano players and writers, Roger Kellaway.

RK: Thank you, Monk.

MR: Welcome.

RK: My pleasure to be here.

MR: Can I ask you if someone met you that you didn't know at all and they asked you what's your profession, how do you describe yourself?

RK: I describe myself as an improviser who uses jazz.

MR: Okay. So improvising to you is not necessarily only a jazz — in the jazz idiom.

RK: That's right. And the reason that I decided on that particular category for myself is because the idea of what a jazz pianist does is too limiting. I've listened to much too much twentieth century classical music, which is the necessary ingredient for your understanding how it is I play and how I think, for me to just think of myself as a jazz pianist, because there's too much Webern and Alban Berg and Prokofiev and Stravinsky, and onward to Stockhausen and Messiaen and more modern composers that have shaped my thinking about what sound is about. And I merely superimpose many of those ideas over any given moment, on any given tune.

MR: When you play, for instance I'll use last night as an example, I heard you play "All Blues." It was very interesting because we weren't sure what the tune was going to be, and you started playing, you and Bob Magnusson just basically started playing. Do you have an idea before your hands hit the keyboard, as where that's going, that introduction?

RK: No. Well the answer is yes and no. Because we had never played that tune that way.

MR: No?

RK: Until we recorded it. The CD has not been released, there's a CD called "Timepiece" that's in the can. And on that session Bob and I decided to do a dorian mode improvisation before we start the tune. So I don't know when the tune is going to start, but I do know that's the tune that it's hooked up to. There are other times when I've improvised with Eddie Daniels for instance where we just start and we go and whatever happens and whatever the tune emerges is the tune that emerges, if it does.

MR: You mean you don't even have a goal down the road in mind? It may come into — he may start playing "These Foolish Things" or something, and—

RK: And I may go with it.

MR: Or you say I don't want to play that one. That's interesting.

RK: Now in 1980 I did an album which is also in the can with a wonderful English saxophonist and clarinetist, Tony Coe. Tony was best remembered, or he is probably best remembered in history for having done some of the English Peter Sellers movies with Hank Mancini. But I heard him play a couple of love ballads for me and then I went to an avante garde concert where he played with Derek Bailey, who is the English equivalent of Anton Webern and plays jazz. It was unbelievable. And I said that's my guy. So I took Tony into the studio, with John Richards, one of the greatest engineers ever, in CTS Wembley, a huge studio, and in four hours we made a free form album. We played one blues, that was the last thing we did. Every other tune was of no conception to start off, we just started. And it was amazing, because it's so cohesive.

MR: Wow. And it must have given the blues a certain amount of — I'm not sure what — finality or when you finally got there.

RK: You could have looked at the blues, if we were to hear it now, more in line with the way you may know how I play. Because you're familiar with the ground bass of what I'm superimposing my ideas on. When it's just free form you are either going to go on the trip or you're not, and if you are not comfortable with abstraction, perhaps you won't go, or you'll resist it, which in some cases is a pity and in other cases absolutely not a pity, because it wasn't worth going in the first place.

MR: When did this twentieth century, for lack of a better term, classical music enter into your thinking?

RK: You know I can't remember a time when it wasn't there because when I was going to school, and I mean now let's see it wouldn't be grammar school, probably junior high school, I used to have, you know people use coffee timers for their coffee? My coffee timer was for my phonograph. So I would wake up and the phonograph would go on, and I would listen to maybe Woody Herman's Third Herd, followed by Alban Berg's "Lulu

Suite", followed by maybe Spike Jones, followed by Art Tatum. So the mixture of things was always churning. It wasn't until so many years later that what I actually realized was it was all about sound. That's what interests me. I mean melody interests me greatly also, especially because it's connected to the heart. But what is the sound of that melody? So the sound spectrum is what interests me. And I like to listen to a whole bunch of different people that treat the sound spectrum in different ways. Like Stravinsky treats it in a different way than Messiaen, or than Gil Evans. When I listen to jazz it's usually to writers, then Duke Ellington, or Fletcher Henderson, so that there's a whole historical aspect of how I think also, which comes from Fats Waller and then from my buddy Dick Sudhalter, who I went to high school with and we used to play in his basement and listen to Bix Beiderbecke records and Louis Armstrong and all the true beginnings of the history of jazz, so there's that part of me also.

MR: Interesting to see his name recently too on a new book that's out.

RK: Yeah. He's an excellent writer. And as I mentioned last night I brought a CD with me that he's on that is a fortieth reunion of a band we played with in — well we started in junior high school, but in high school. And forty years later we did another concert together, about a year ago, and we made a CD of it.

MR: Was it true that you were caddies?

RK: Yeah. I was a C caddy.

MR: A C caddy?

RK: Yeah. I needed glasses at the time. I used to have this left handed lady that divotted every time she hit the ball and the ball would go up in the air and it'd only need to get about 50 feet and I never could see where it went. I kept going to the caddy next to me, "Hey, where's the ball?" But she loved me.

MR: You might have a future as an umpire or something if you kept that up.

RK: Well the guy that played alto sax on this CD is a member of that country club and a mover and shaker in the community.

MR: All right.

RK: A huge real estate mogul and he's building two golf courses as we speak, one in his back yard so he doesn't have to go anywhere.

MR: Well let me comment on a few things that I have read and you can tell me if they're accurate or not — that some of your jazz interest came from hearing George Shearing?

RK: George Shearing was my very first influence. I used to play "I'll Remember April," which his arrangement came out in sheet music. And when I was 13 — I started crossing over into jazz when I was around that age — and I was a professional at 14. But prior to that I was playing that piece. That was my favorite piece of music. I love those early solo

things of George's and from Shearing it went on to Billy Taylor, and then Oscar Peterson and then Horace Silver. And in the interim, Fats Waller was mixed in with all of that. Fats more than any of the others, more than James P. Johnson or any of the others. Jimmy Yancy is a boogie piano player that I came across in the 60s when I was working for a copyist. I had to do some takedowns and I discovered him.

MR: Oh, you had to listen to the recording?

RK: Yeah and there were four tracks that were identical. I was supposed to make lead sheets for copyright purposes and I had to figure out these four tracks and how to make them different. But yeah, George was the first main influence.

MR: The New England Conservatory, you went there and you played bass and piano?

RK: The first year I was a piano major and a bass minor, and I was studying with Georges Muller on bass, who was the first bassist with the Boston Symphony, and Roland Nadeau on piano. I had taught myself how to read bass music and how to play the instrument because in junior high school there were eight pianists that wanted to play and the band director said, "How would you like to play one of those?" And I said, "Fine." So I became a bass player. And I did that for ten years including amateur symphony work. So it probably contributes to my love for strings a lot. I adore strings. And it probably led directly to the formation of my group the Cello Quartet, which was in the 70s.

MR: Yeah I want to talk about that but down the line just a little bit. You played, your studies in the conservatory were mostly of a classical nature?

RK: Well they were except at that time we had a pop department. And a pop department at that time meant a jazz department.

MR: Ahh. That's an important statement. I mean from a historical standpoint. Pop music was jazz, or jazz tinged.

RK: It was much more jazz oriented at that time. Just like what's jazz? I mean it's — the definition of jazz now has gotten so absurd that there are players that are supposedly qualified as jazz players that aren't jazz players at all. And their music isn't jazz. We don't need to go into that. There are too many of them. But I stayed in the Conservatory for two years. The second year I was a composition major with Jed Cooke, and a piano minor. And I kept studying bass, and I had choir. Choral was conducted by a woman named Cooke deVaron. And I had eleven years of choral training, which is probably the best ear training that anyone could ever have. But I love singing. We sang with the Boston Symphony and all the major requiems plus Honegger, the "Honegger Christmas Cantata" — it's one of the greatest pieces ever written for me. And in high school we played Menotti's "Amahl and the Night Visitors" and we had a very adventurous high school. We had two years of theory, college credit. And an orchestra under Don March

that played all the Brandenberg concerti plus Haydn and Mozart symphonies, and we had a marching band and a jazz band. An amazing — Newton High School was like the number three high school in the country at one point there. And that's where Sudhalter and I went to school, and most of this band. Bud Farrington, who was the drummer in our group who ended up to be a Major General I think it's called, or Brigadier General, Vietnam and all that.

MR: So you went to the guidance counselor at Newton High School and she says, "What do you want to do?" At that point in your musical development did you have a specific idea of how you wanted to make your living in music?

RK: No, I didn't. But I did have a specific idea that it was going to be music. That happened when I was 12. I didn't know exactly where it was going, yes I was daydreaming all the time waiting for the gigs on weekends, and by the time I was 16 I was then playing in Boston and playing Dixieland. I was meeting Ruby Braff, I was playing with Dick Wetmore, who is really an unknown to most people who taught me who Django Reinehardt was, he played cornet, violin and baritone horn and still does. Prodigy violinist classically. But played jazz, and we were doing jazz and poetry playing off of twelve tone rows with Palmer French who was reading e e cummings. And I'm 16, 17 years old and going wow, what is this, and how do I add that to mix that I just gave you about 15 minutes ago, you know to Berg and Spike Jones and King Oliver.

MR: Spike Jones. Spike Jones is a great thing to be influenced by. What did you like about Spike Jones?

RK: I just loved the humor. Great humor. And the lesson from that is, as I learned later when I wrote some comedic things, if the players think they're funny, the music isn't. It has to be played straight so that the humor of the music makes its own comment.

MR: Well he had some pretty good musicians pulling that stuff off.

RK: Great musicians.

MR: Especially when you watch the live stuff — to do what they were doing and play that music.

RK: We have a harpist, Goodspeed I think her name is, she lives in Ojai. She worked with Spike Jones. And she told me the oddest story. They were in some theater and the harp fell off the stage and hit a trampoline and it bounced up in the air and Spike came up to her and said, "Could you do that every night?"

MR: There you go.

RK: It's the insanity of that. And my father-in-law knows, one of his good friends, I can't remember if it's Earl Bennett or not — actually also played with Spike Jones and said it

was some of the most outrageous times of his life. I never met him, I always appreciate his outrageous sense of humor.

MR: The first compositions of your own, did you start writing in high school?

RK: We wrote in high school because we had as a graduation assignment in high school, two years of theory, at the end of which you had to write a piece for orchestra, which I wrote a piece for orchestra, for piano and orchestra, and I was going to conduct it, and the pianist never showed up for the rehearsal, so I had to play piano and conduct it. And that's kind of where it began. I had a jazz band at the conservatory and I started doing more compositions then. Then after that I went on the road and I was playing bass with Ralph Marterie's big band and I became part of an arranger's competition with Joe Farrell and Bobby Ojeda. At that time, until I met Bobby, I was the youngest member of any band I played in. And Bobby was a year younger than I was.

MR: Is he the trumpet player?

RK: Yeah.

MR: Who was with Basie for —

RK: Basie I think and I don't know if he — I don't remember exactly what bands he was with. Maybe Kenton also.

MR: And '63, early 60s you started getting out with some of the well known names.

RK: Well I arrived in New York in 1960. Here's an interesting story. I arrived, and the first night I meet Bill Takas, the bass player. And he takes me to the Five Spot and introduces me to Jimmy Giuffre. I sit in with Jimmy Giuffre and I'm actually offered the job on bass. Now as it turns out, I didn't take it obviously. The next group he had was Paul Bley and Steve Swallow. And that was, he wanted a band of composers. That happened to me twice. The other person it happened with was Maynard Ferguson, who actually offered me the job on bass or piano, whatever I wanted. I reminded him of that a year ago when we had dinner together because he lives in Ojai. So that was an interesting time. I opted to stay home and write acts for singers and eat lots of hamburgers and milkshakes for a few years and sort of eventually get into the studios. And Dave Bailey was looking for a pianist, Dave Frishberg was going with Allen Zoot and the position of piano with Clark Terry and Bob Brookmeyer was open and he got me that, and that became two and a half years and ultimately led to wonderful relationships.

MR: Clark's a great fellow to work with I would imagine.

RK: Oh fabulous. And again, here you have, there's a predictable aspect. I don't mean this as any kind of criticism, this is merely an observation from thinking about the stage of the Half Note in New York where the piano was always facing one of the walls and the band was behind you. So you never saw anybody in the band unless you turned around. So you

never had the distraction of anything that was happening visually, so you just listened for all that time. So there was a kind of a straight-aheadness and predictability about where Clark would go, and a totally unpredictable aspect of Brookmeyer. So along with the other scenarios that I've given you, I was in the cage at the time, I was also into a marriage with a woman that absolutely detested everything twentieth century and really made my life miserable, so I got deeply into twentieth century music, to the point where I said hey I love this. So I was bringing these ideas to the gig. And when Clark wasn't there and it was just Brookmeyer, sometimes it would happen. I remember going to a John Cage concert and Edgar Varese was there and I happened to mention it to Dave Bailey. And all he said was, "I hope you left it there." I said, "Ohhh." And Clark wasn't going to come on the first set it was just Brookmeyer so all hell broke loose. I was playing on the piano with drum sticks and just let it all go wherever it was going to go. I knew Bob would go there.

MR: Did the audience go with you?

RK: I guess so. It was a while ago. I mean it never seemed to be so far out that it left any kind of musicality. That was always there.

MR: Well in 1964 you recorded with Ben Webster, Maynard Ferguson, Wes Montgomery, Sonny Rollins—

RK: It wasn't, not Maynard.

MR: Not Maynard?

RK: No.

MR: Okay. But there's still — your name was obviously getting around as a —

RK: Yeah those are the years I was doing things with Oliver Nelson. Some of the best recordings I ever made I thought. "Alfie" with Sonny Rollins, "Bumpin'" with Wes Montgomery, and "More Blues and the Abstract Truth" with Ollie. I mean those were really favorite times. We'd go into the studio and just eat the music alive. We'd be sight reading and playing it like we'd played it for three weeks. It was amazing, just ferocious. "More Blues and the Abstract Truth" was designed for three days and we essentially finished in one and just danced in the studio for the rest of the time, except for "More Blues and the Abstract Truth" which was so difficult we had to take that one home and bring it back. Everything else on that album is a first take.

MR: I see. Yeah he had quite a success with that, the first one, and he really made his name, didn't he?

RK: Um hum. Incredible talent. Bartok lover.

MR: Oliver Nelson loved Bartok.

RK: He's one of those people that got away. I never spent enough time with him. I adored him. And we make assumptions that we don't think about, about relationships and then we get on in life and suddenly people—

MR: Leave.

RK: Transform and that's it and it's gone, and you think wow, how did I let that one get away? But we did spend a little time together, mostly in the studio.

MR: And he preceded you to Los Angeles, right? Did he move out here before you? '66?

RK: No I think I came out first. I came out the Las Vegas, first with Jack E. Leonard. I was with Jack for a year and wrote some charts for him and essentially was his musical director and I became a stooge, for which I learned how to deadpan an audience and get a laugh all the way around. He'd say, "Was the ground cold when you woke up this morning?" I had the beard and that was one of his stock lines.

MR: Elaborate on that.

RK: I can't — okay Jack was the forerunner of the insult comics.

MR: Okay. Jack E. Leonard, yeah.

RK: Yeah. He came before Don Rickles. He was such a sensitive guy, it was amazing. He asked me what time it was one night at the Copacabana, and I said, "I don't know, I don't have a watch." And the next day there was an Henri Gireaux watch and he was so sensitive. I never really got this, the desire for the perhaps father-son relationship because I was kind of young at the time I was doing this. But I adored him. He's one of the great people in my life because he was out of vaudeville and the vaudeville people have a whole feeling about show business that's just different. It's more like the show must go on than the mental gymnastics that other generations undertake. So it was Jack for a year. Well he would say "was the ground cold when you woke up this morning?" Meaning the beard, and I would do a straight face. And I would look out and I would get a laugh. And what he got me to do was to start with one side of the audience and just slowly pan around as I don't crack a smile. And I would get a laugh all the way around. It was kind of a vaudeville kick and I really enjoyed that.

MR: You've got to learn the power of understatement too.

RK: Yeah. I was the guy who always wrote the charts that nobody could play. So that was Jack. And then Bobby Darin was next.

MR: Yeah, how did that come about?

RK: Jack and Bobby Darin, through the two of them I learned my sense of stage timing. I don't know how I got that interview. I can tell you that it was on Vine Street in Steve Allen's old office. It was an old studio years and years ago. And I walked in and Bobby was sitting on this big throne chair, it had sort of a ten foot back to it, and I was amused

by that. And somewhere during the day he said, well I guess he had decided that I was okay and that we'd work together, and he said, "By the way go check the files and look for [sings] the shadow of your smile [scats]." So I said, "Okay." So I went through the files and I found all the charts on "The Shadow of Your Smile" and I came back and we were opening the following Tuesday in Las Vegas. It was a Friday. And I said, "I'm sorry Mr. Darin, there doesn't seem to be a chart that goes [sings] the shadow of your smile." He says, just a little arrogant, "We both had that." He said, his answer to that was, "Well there will be by Tuesday, won't there?" And that was the beginning of our relationship.

MR: Wow.

RK: So I took a lot of dictation, because he really knew a lot about what he wanted in charts. And at the end of a year he gave me "Dr. Doolittle." He called me up in Las Vegas and he said basically, "Kellaway get your ass over here." I said, "Okay, I'll be right there" and came over. And he said, "In three weeks we're going to record this music and this is your instrumentation." He gave me the entire instrumentation, I don't know why, and I always liked it from a challenge aspect. We had 35 pieces and a few horns and I know I used Tom Scott and John Guerin and Chuck Domanico and four track mind you, and one track for the vocal. So only three tracks for the orchestra. And I wrote it all in three weeks and it was completely designed for Bobby because I was totally into him. And we've waited 32 years for that to come out on CD. Well CDs haven't been around for 32 years, but the album was so short lived that you couldn't find it and it has just now come out — an English company is pressing it. "The Music Machine" is the name of the company in I think it's Maryland. You have to call them, you can't find it in a store. But there it is, it's been re-mixed and I shall give Guerin a copy of it tonight as a gift.

MR: All right. You have a copy already.

RK: I have it, yeah. It's—

MR: Some of your best work do you think?

RK: I measure my work by, did I do the very best that I could at the time. And this is definitely something that lives with me. I can play some of these charts and just go right back to stage and it's the energy and the love and all, of making music together. And incidentally, as an aside, I just finished a CD which is a "Bobby Darin Homage" with Gary LeMel as the vocalist, president of Warner Brothers music, ex bass player, and Bobby Colomby of Blood Sweat and Tears is the producer and I'm the arranger. We had Elvin Jones, we had the Brecker Brothers, we had — Bobby Colomby, we were having lunch together and he said, "When was the last vocal album you ever saw Elvin Jones' name on?" I said, "I've never." He said, "Yeah, exactly. We're going to use Elvin." So we go to the Jazz Bakery and we meet Elvin. I hadn't seen Elvin in 15 years. We played

something at the mayor's house in New York years and years ago for George Wein or some party. And he said, "I'd love to do it." In fact the first thing he said to me, which is one of the dearest things that anybody's ever said to me, we were hugging and he whispered in my ear, "Thad always talked about you." And it was just like wow.

MR: That's high praise.

RK: I said oh man, how nice. Because I played with Thad's Ball of Fire big band in Europe in '83, we did a concert and a bunch of recordings, and he was part of "More Blues and the Abstract Truth."

MR: That's great company. You've had kind of the cream on a lot of your projects. And you know it's a long way from Anton Webern to Tom Scott and Joni Mitchell. You really kind of have this huge attention span and curiosity I guess.

RK: Yeah that's what it is, it is. It's a curiosity. It's an insatiable curiosity to understand how different ways of making music are achieved. So if you're writing a comedy you do one thing, if you're writing a horror picture you're doing another thing and if it's something that I'm asked to do that I've never done before I don't say I can't do that, I say I can do it, and I do my homework until I understand how it's done, and then I go about doing it my way. But that's the reason for all that. I love Joni Mitchell. That tour was fabulous and Guerin was on that. Guerin called me and said, "You want to go out of town?" I said, "Yeah, let's go." Because Joe Sample wasn't available for the tour and of course we had the old quartet which was Guerin, Tom Scott, Chuck Domanico and myself. In fact I was the leader or Tom was the leader depending upon who got the gig. So I became part of the L.A. Express. My only regret of that whole time is that out of 55 concerts, we recorded 9 times, and there wasn't a single time that Joni liked it. And then Tom and I decided that we were going to go in different directions so I left the L.A. Express and Victor Feldman took my place and the very next time they recorded became "Miles of Aisles."

MR: "Miles of Aisles."

RK: Yeah. And that's all the stuff I played 55 times. So I missed that one.

MR: That's not great timing. Can I play a couple of things for you?

RK: Sure.

[audio interlude]

RK: It has an interesting history.

MR: That particular tune?

RK: Yeah. It's called "In the Heat of the Night" and it was first written as a demonstration for someone that wanted a film theme. And I wrote this piece and this person said that it wasn't a memorable enough melody, which to me is a joke, because that's definitely who

I am, I can write a memorable melody. And this is — I guess that's my answer to — my new agent would call it deafness. And that's why I took this guy on. His name is Stephen Kagan, and one of the things he said to me is, "Look, let's get this understood right out front—"

MR: Well he sounds like a producer right away.

RK: "But all the people I'm going to send your music to are deaf." I said, "I love you." Plus he's a tubist and he reads music, he understands what creativity is all about, and how could I not want to be with somebody like that?"

MR: Okay, I misunderstood—

RK: It's the grounding of understanding that yes, you and I are going to talk about creativity to probably greater lengths than maybe either of us ever want to, but once it goes beyond us out to the business and the people that are in control, we're dealing with people that, not only do they not know anything about music, but they think you're over the hill if 43 is now considered to be the peak of your life as far as working for someone. So if you're 44 you're probably going to get fired. Well but the people who are doing this I assume are probably younger and they're kind of accountants. How would they possibly understand, I'm about to be 60 this year, how I could bring all of what it is I know to my craft. It isn't measured. The CD "Timepiece" went to Atlantic. The comment came back, "One of the most astounding CDs I've ever heard in my life, but I'm not signing anyone over 25."

MR: Oh no. They really said that?

RK: Yeah. That was the comment. Yeah.

MR: That's a sad state of affairs.

RK: Well it's a stupid state of affairs. It doesn't make any sense. Because okay, 25 is a nice age. I played a lot of notes at 25.

MR: Yes. And how many of them would you throw away now?

RK: I don't know. Well according to the way I play some ballads it's probably three-quarters of them I'd throw away. Well it's kind of, what I'm saying is it's the nature of the business. You get into film composition and you hear scores that are written by people who probably did a lot of music videos. They know a lot about technology but they haven't a clue about how to write. There are many who do — Goldsmith, Jerry, is probably the daddy at this point.

MR: Yeah.

RK: But theme and variations and meaningful, — a colored thematic piece of material that has a color about it that you can identify with and is developed throughout the film is almost non-existent. It isn't even a pattern that people know, and many of the people who are

making films apparently are so brainwashed by the idea of the almighty soundtrack album that they keep putting songs in all the time. And think about this. We come to a point in a film where there's a plot, where the story is going to move on. And in older times there was nothing in there except a piece of orchestral music, and we used our imagination as to connecting to the story and how it went forward. Now they give you a song. Why? Because the generations that have grown up from the '60s have been mostly song-oriented people and the subjectivity of words is what these people are thinking about. They think we need the subjectivity of words to take us from point A to point B. Because they do.

MR: Because they're of the generation that's producing it now, so—

RK: Yeah. It's T.V. stuff. It's all being done for you. There's no imagination. You don't have a chance to exercise that. Amazing. So I have to feel very lucky about my timing.

MR: Let me put this on.

[audio interlude]

MR: I have to say that — I'm not sure I can put this into words — that piece of music has so many different things in it, so many different emotions and styles. Every time I listen to it it seems to take on another dimension. And I'm wondering if other people felt that and if that's why this music caught on with a real corps of listeners.

RK: I don't know. That corps of listeners is still there. I'll tell you how this happened. I was doing a lot of studio work at the time in the late 60s, and I worked a lot with Edgar Lustgarden. And I had Edgar come over to my house and we played through a few original pieces. My desire was to write, I wanted to play piano and cello music but I wanted to write it. And Edgar was completely okay with that idea and that gave birth to the cello quartet, which became a marriage of wood. That was the whole point of that. It was cello, piano, bass and marimba. Now all these years later I'm now putting together a re-make or another, a new cello quartet if you want to call it that. And it will be with Chuck Domanico and Emil Richards, again, and the cellist will be Joan Jeanrenaud of the Kronos String Quartet. Now I saw the Kronos Quartet a year ago in Santa Barbara and I had an instinct just to take a cassette of the Cello Quartet albums to her, just to see if we had a communication. I'd never met her. Lo and behold she knew the music, she was delighted, and we had a — it was a wonderful communication. Because I would truthfully like to write some things for Kronos, especially some jazz things, because I've never been too happy with the kinds of things that are written for them from a jazz standpoint. But to make a long story short, I'm going next week to Tucson to do a concert with Paul Horn and somebody from a newspaper called me to do a phone interview, and said by the way, well naturally any kind of an interview at some point gets around to the

subject of twentieth century classical music, perhaps too much for the jazz people who like me, but he said, "By the way the Kronos I saw last night and the cellist isn't with them." I said, "What? What happened?" She's on sabbatical. I called my manager immediately, I said, "Find Joan Jeanrenaud." And she called back the next day and we started talking about this idea. She said I have nothing going on next fall, we can get together in June. I have to go to Ireland and play a cello concerto and so I'm very excited about this.

MR: Great. Was some of this music not notated — how do I put it — there was some room for interpretation.

RK: Yes. When you think about for instance the opening section of "Sunrise" for cello and piano is written in noteheads. There were no stems and no bar lines, no expression marks, nothing, merely the noteheads. And it might be a filled-in notehead to a notehead that wouldn't be filled in, which would indicate perhaps a longer, that I desired for that note to be held longer. But as far as the overall expression that happens, that's up to Edgar. And I will do some more pieces like that for Joan because what it does is it gives the classical player an opportunity of reading it as written, which is very comfortable for them, but with the latitude to express it however they wish. And however they express it I will be with them, because that's completely comfortable for me, whatever the pacing is it will work. So that's as far as the improvisation goes for the cello.

MR: The music, a lot of it seems to lend itself to some visual images. Has anybody ever approached you about doing that?

RK: The only thing, years and years and years and years ago there was piece done on The Today Show with a photographer. It was about a photographer. Boyd Matson, I was trying to think of his name, Boyd Matson was the moderator and Bob Flick had something to do with that before he joined as head writer for, he's now retired, from Entertainment Tonight. So the segment was about a photographer and they used the Cello Quartet music and it worked beautifully. So my wife is in video and she's thought about it for many years. We'll get into it.

MR: Great. You've done some fairly well known films, and do you like writing for film?

RK: Yeah. I haven't done it for a long time. I mean I left it for about 14 years until about a year and a half ago when this director called me, Karen Arthur called me and said I've got this project that you should really think about it. So it was called "Journey of the Heart," it was about an autistic savant from Waltham, Massachusetts, unbelievably. That's where he lives, where I went to junior high school, and starring Cybil Shepherd. So I did this movie for CBS and I really enjoy it. I enjoy it a lot. So I'm putting together some midi ideas and gear and thinking about getting more into technology.

MR: I was just going to — yeah, you made me think of — does your curiosity extend into the available technology these days to supposedly make your life more creative?

RK: It doesn't make it more creative. And it doesn't make it faster.

MR: You can see where I'm coming from too.

RK: Those are the two things. I went to the NAMM show a couple of years ago, and I went up to get a demonstration of Sibelius software, which I'd been interested in, it's a writing program. This guy proceeded to show me how to compose with the computer. As I was watching this I kept saying to him no, no, no, no, no. I'm not interested in this. I will never be interested in this. And he said, "Let me show you how to do this." And I kept saying my line and he kept — this is what he was going to show me because he's programmed to show me. I said, "Look, let me get this idea straight to you. I write with a pencil and paper. That is how I write. I am an acoustic person. It has to do with the emotion that my body feels from the ideas going on the paper, and the pencil of it is the hands of the earth or however you want to think of it metaphorically. And I will use the midi and computer to realize that. I haven't quite got all this through my head yet even, that I don't need to ever go to the studio in a way to do something that's 80 or 90 pieces, when I have all of the samples available to me, I'm learning how to hard drive and record and all of those things. But the main ideas go down on paper. I couldn't possibly spend my time clicking a mouse for one note. When you go [whistles] and you've got a whole chord. And you can assign it to 40 people in a second. No, no, no, no. That's nonsense. But the idea of perhaps playing an idea into a synthesizer and suddenly having it printed out for you, that's great. I think that's a boon. And we need to have, I think, combinations of synthetic music and acoustic music, it's going to be okay. I do find it ironic however when people talk about so-called electronic music because when I think of electronic music I think of Stockhausen and Dofschtetter and Luening and Ussachevsky and all the people from the 60s that I used to listen to that didn't have any of these instruments. Edgar Varese and they were just doing tape manipulation and it was so adventurous and imaginative. Alwin Nicoli, did you ever—

MR: No I'm not familiar with him.

RK: Alwin Nicoli what a guy. I was hanging out with some kind of out people in New York that really loved avante garde. Once they discovered that I did they took me down to hear Alwin Nicoli one night. And Alwin Nicoli Dance Company, he did the costumes, the lighting, the choreography and the music. And what was astounding, I can remember one piece that he did where he had this whole huge piece of plexiglass that came down behind the dancers and the dancers had wrist bands that were attacked to the plexiglas so that

every time they made a movement they stretched the plexiglas into a different shape and lights would cascade around — what is this? Yeah it was crazy.

MR: Cool. What's in the can for you right now?

RK: Well we finished the Gary LeMel project, that will come out probably in March, that's the "Bobby Darin Homage," to which we recorded Paula Cole doing — the song has escaped me.

MR: A Darin song?

RK: Yeah. We did "Mack the Knife" and we did "Beyond the Sea" of the huge hits. And everything else that we picked for the album we picked from songs he recorded but not necessarily the biggest hits.

MR: I assume you skipped over "Splish Splash"—

RK: I believe we did.

MR: "I was Taking a Bath."

RK: Yes. Didn't even put my foot in the water.

MR: Ooh, good one.

RK: No, no. no.

MR: Yeah he—

RK: Didn't want to do that. I did it on stage with him and did "If I Were A Carpenter," and I was aboard some of those recordings.

MR: How often do you hear things these days that you're playing on?

RK: Well not very often because I don't listen to anything that would tell me.

MR: Okay.

RK: I have so little time that it turns out, to listen. When I'm driving, quite often it's in silence and fortunately I'm blessed with a wife that also agrees with the concept.

MR: I'll bet there's not silence in your head.

RK: Well I can be driving along and looking at a mountain range and just enjoying that existence without a great deal of mental mess. I'm still trying to think of this tune that I recorded with Paula Cole on Sammy Cahn.

MR: Can you hum it? I guess if you remembered the name you could hum it right away.

RK: "Call Me Irresponsible."

MR: Ah, there we go.

RK: So it's a duet with Paula Cole. She came in and sang beautifully, and I still really don't know who she is musically. I know she's a big star and she got five Grammys last year and all of that. But in our meeting she wanted me to dictate what I wanted her to sing, in solfege. So right away my opinion about here shot up about 25 points.

MR: That she even knew the word, right?

RK: Yeah. And I said, in my arrogance, okay, moveable do or fixed do? She said moveable do. I said great, okay. So I mean I hadn't even thought about solfege in probably 30 years. So we're doing all the chromatics and everything and I'm teaching her the lines to solfege. And wow, it was great. And she sung beautifully. So that's the duet. That will probably be AM crossover. So there's that and the new cello quartet project and I'm taking on a new agent for film and Gary George is my new manager and he's someone that — I worked for a couple of his clients years ago. He feels strongly about the film area, and I like that idea.

MR: Is the Los Angeles music scene for you — I'm not sure how to say this. We always hear about the rat race and it's who you know, and all that kind of — extraneous to the music. Do you have to partake in that?

RK: You see, I never really did. I never played that game. I have many colleagues that got a lot more work than I did because they did. They kept going to parties and hooking up with this and networking. I'd say probably that I'm more interested in that now than I was in the past because I do enjoy it and obviously the more public my image becomes the more power I have and the more versatile projects will come to me and there is just more things I can do. It's actually a necessity, I really need that. When you look at the 18 years that I spent being a film composer where my colleagues like Herbie Hancock and Chick Corea and Keith Jarrett didn't do that. They stayed out there. So I waited 18 years and then went out there and I had people saying "wow, where'd you come from?" Or said, "Gee I love 'Alfie'" or, "where's the cello? Don't you play cello?"

MR: Yeah? Don't you play cello. That's good.

RK: So I know that I'm more interested in a public image now than I ever have been. But I live 80 miles away, so what does that say? You know? I want to live in paradise you know. I don't want to be doing meetings every day in Hollywood.

MR: Do you have an opinion about the state of jazz music today?

RK: Not really. Because well I mean I have a few ideas. There are many people that are on the scene that I haven't heard because I really don't spend any time paying attention to what's going on in jazz. If I have an opportunity to listen to something I want to hear somebody write something. Or I might listen to Rob McConnell or Gil Evans or Duke Ellington, people that are jazz oriented writers. But to hear an album featuring another wonderful player? Well okay. Most of the time if it's really that good I'd like to be with it. You know it's fun to do that, where you hear somebody and you say gee I'd like to play with that person. I suppose I have the same disgruntled opinion that most people my age have about unedited playing.

MR: Unedited.

RK: Yeah. People that came up, let's say on the end of Coltrane and never knew the development of Coltrane. So they came up with [scats].

MR: Yeah they started listening to him right there.

RK: Yeah. And I happened to walk out on that concert, because I was bored. And it's extremely difficult to play a solo for 10 or 15 minutes and have it be interesting, and I've only met a handful of players in my whole life that could do it. And I'm not sure that Coltrane is one of them. But thinking about my background and having grown up through Dixieland, let's not just take Dixieland, let's go back to Stravinsky's "Serenade in A" for piano. It was written for 78s. In recording, there couldn't be a movement that was over three minutes. Now look at that as a piece of editing. Now you go on to Dixieland, which was also done on 78s, so you couldn't do a tune that was beyond three minutes. It wasn't until extended play 45s came in that things started to expand, and then LPs. But the players that are the most interesting to me are the players that have grown up through some degree of editing, so that they understand what the shape of a short solo is, and more often than not, can play a much longer solo with the same shape, with the same understanding of what the shape of a solo is about. That way you can keep somebody's interest, it isn't just a matter of self indulgence.

MR: Yeah, that's a good statement, and it's interesting when you think about how music reproduction technology has helped to shape the music. The limits that were put on it, as you say, really affected the way a person could write, and in some cases very positively. I have three minutes to make a statement here.

RK: Yeah you can take that to film music. Film music will give you, how about eight point seven seconds? I like that challenge, I really do. In many cases it's a lot easier than 20 minutes.

MR: Um hum. Get in and get out.

RK: And fade out before it goes to black. It's just a technique. You get to learn, you learn what the technique is and then you find your ultimate freedom within that.

MR: Well I'm looking forward to hearing the Bobby Darin project.

RK: It's wonderful really. We were sitting down at lunch and Colomby's looking at me and saying, "You know, I'm really thinking about this as extended arrangements." I said, "Yeah?" He said, "Yeah, some like five, six, seven minutes." I said, "Really? With a vocal?" He said, "Yeah. The vocal is only going to be just like an instrument." I turned to Gary LeMel and said, "Really? You're up for this?" He said, "Yeah, yeah, it's great, love the idea." So I said to Bobby Colomby, "Well sort of what parameters do you want me to think about?" He said, "Oh I don't know, somewhere between Gil Evans and Claus Ogerman." I said, "Really?" Licking my chops. I said, "Ooh, baby." So we have this

opportunity to — and I got Elvin Jones and I got the Brecker Brothers and I got this wonderful cellist. So we went from "Easy Living," which is Michael Brecker and myself and cello, we went from there all the way to "Mack the Knife" with a big band and going through all the lyrics of "Mack the Knife," including the German lyrics, so there's like ten choruses that start in Germany and then go through Dixieland and then go to modern swing band and then end up in Germany again. It's very interesting.

MR: I guess they got the right guy to do that.

RK: Well in 1990 I did a show in Germany, it was a Kurt Weill show for his, I think his 90th birthday for the WDR band in Cologne. And wow what a joy that was. And Caterina Valente singing, another person from vaudeville by the way. Amazing talent.

MR: Well Mr. Kellaway, I'm very glad you joined me today.

RK: Well I'm very pleased to be here.

MR: Because I've been looking forward to talking to you since hearing your music for many years, and I knew you'd have some interesting things to say.

RK: I got very charged by this. I just got up on a roll here. It's nice.

MR: Well I hope you have a good session tonight.

RK: Thanks Monk.

MR: And I'll be listening. So thanks for your time.

RK: All right. Thank you.